A Vicious Circle

There is no clear reason why so many teachers' posts lie vacant in Gujarat's schools. Some put it down to plain government apathy. However, some teachers' unions allege that the government wants to exit primary education, where the crisis is acute, and shut down grant-in-aid primary schools. They maintain that a vicious cycle is wearing down Gujarat's schools—many grant-in-aid schools lost aid due to poor results and are in a poor condition; many of them have low staff strength in the first place and so can't help students prepare for exams, leading to poor results. "Without teachers, students are unable to perform in board exams, and thus grants stop," says Priyavadan Korat, a Rajkot-based member of the GSHSEB and a member of the Gujarat Teachers' Union Coordination Committee, a representative of five teachers' unions. "Without teachers, students drop out in earlier grades too. Those who can afford it shift to private schools, but a majority of students in the backward rural and poor urban areas leave schooling. And so schools shut down." Twenty-five grant-in-aid schools shut down in Ahmedabad last year, adds Vyas, even as permission was given for 260 new private schools in the state.

Besides private schools being expensive and beyond the reach of many, Korat points out that they do not operate in remote and tribal areas, where students require special care. The government, he says, has not recruited full-time teachers since 2009, and vacancies have crept up steadily. In 2016, 2017 and 2018, TAT exams were duly announced, but cancelled after repeated question paper leaks. As a remedial measure, over 13,000 teaching assistants or Shikshan Sahayaks—who haven't cleared TAT or B.Ed—were appointed to grant-in-aid secondary and higher secondary schools in the last decade. The Bapunagar Municipal school is a case in point.

Reducing Dropouts

Gujarat education secretary Vinod Rao has denied that the government intends to encourage private schools at the cost of government/ grant-in-aid ones, claiming that besides teaching assistants, staff is being appointed under the government's Gyan Sahayak scheme to address the shortage. Besides, he points out that the overall student dropout statistics of Gujarat have improved. A press statement from the education department claims the dropout rate of students going from upper primary class 8 to secondary school class 9 has reduced from 23 per cent in 2021-22 to 5.5 per cent in 2023-24. The dropout rate in primary grades 1-8 is 2.8 per cent. "About 6,000 teachers under the Shikshan Sahayak policy have been appointed in the past two years and 2,500 head teachers have been recruited. Another 11,000 teachers are being recruited under the Gyan Sahayak policy," Rao says.

The Gyan Sahayak scheme is an arrangement to fill vacancies by recruiting teachers who have cleared TAT and have a B.Ed degree on 11-month contracts instead of full-time employment. Protesting teachers say that contractual teachers are not interested in relocating to rural areas without a job guarantee. According to figures released in the assembly on September 14, 760 schools depend entirely on 1,885 Shikshan Sahayaks. During the monsoon assembly session in September, Gujarat education minister Kuber Dindor said that this is because the government is not able to find qualified teachers.

Digvijaysinh Jadeja, the president of the Gujarat State Primary Teachers Association, explains how the shortage of teachers is lopsided. "In 15 developed districts, 95 per cent of teachers' posts are filled. But in 10 remote districts, 50 per cent are vacant. Schools in tribal districts like Dahod and regions of central Gujarat, or far-out villages of Kutch are empty boxes, with one or no teacher," he says. The government's solution to merge schools in remote areas and provide them with transportation is not viable, he adds. "Parents won't let their children, especially girls, travel long distances to school," Jadeja points out. According to the Socio Economic Review of Gujarat 2022-23, the pupil teacher ratio (PTR) in secondary and higher secondary is one teacher for 31 students—close to the National Education Policy ideal of 1:30—but it drops to 42.5 in Dahod.

The Annual Status of Education Report, a study conducted by NGO Pratham and released in January 2023, says only 22 per cent children in rural Gujarat can perform basic subtraction in class 3, while 35 per cent in class 5 can read class 2 texts, both lower than the national average of 27 per cent and 39 per cent, respectively. Widespread teaching vacancies across Gujarat are failing students. Only the hiring of qualified teachers can save the situation. ■

CASE OF THE MISSING TEACHERS

- Widespread vacancies in Gujarat's schools, plus the recently scrapped result-linked grant policy, have caused many students to drop out
- From 2021-2023, 257,000 students have dropped out after class 8; the number till July this year is 56,000
- Districts with the most number of schools with only one teacher: Kutch (105), Mahisagar (106), Tapi (84), Banaskantha (40), Devbhoomi Dwarka (46)



"Gujarat's student dropout rate has improved. Also, 2,500 head teachers and 11,000 other teachers are being recruited to address the shortage"

–VINOD RAO
Education Secretary, Gujarat